

<!-- Platform: Blogger | Target: 1,200-2,000 words | Publish: before 2026-05-06 Medium publish Pillar: Career Visibility & Organizational Navigation Impact Labels: Technical visibility, Career development Status: DRAFT. Not approved. -->

****Quick Bridge:**** You have been doing everything right. You talk to your manager about your career goals. You ask what it would take to move into a leadership role. You raise it in every one-on-one. And when the leadership role opens up, it goes to someone else. This post explains what is actually happening in those promotion decisions, why your manager may not be carrying your goals forward, and what you can do to make sure the people who control those decisions know your name and what you want.

Talking to Your Manager About Your Goals Is Not Enough. Here Is What Else You Need to Do.

Most leaders who get passed over for leadership roles were not under-performing. They were invisible to the wrong people.

This is a pattern that shows up in coaching conversations constantly. A high performer who has been clear with their manager about wanting to lead. One-on-ones every week. Goals stated plainly. Years of building toward the next step. And then a role opens up and goes to someone from another team, someone the skip-level already knew, someone whose name was already in the room.

The person who got passed over was not less qualified. They were just unknown to the people making the decision.

The Career Visibility Gap That Stalls Technical Leaders

The advice most people get is straightforward: tell your manager what you want. Be clear about your goals. Show up, do good work, and your manager will advocate for you when the time comes.

That advice is not wrong. It is just incomplete.

Your manager is one voice in the promotion conversation, not the final word. At most organizations, promotion to a leadership role requires sign-off from the hiring manager's boss, input from peers at that level, and sometimes approval from a skip-level leader who has broader organizational authority. If any of those people do not know you, or do not know your goals, they are not in a position to advocate for you.

A leadership promotion is not a performance review. It is a conversation about fit, readiness, and organizational need, happening in a room you are not in. The people in that room are making decisions based on who they know, who they have seen lead, and who they believe is ready.

****If the only person who knows your goals is your direct manager, you have one advocate in that room.**** One advocate who may not even be there if the role is outside their department.

How Promotion Decisions Are Actually Made

According to [research on skip-level management](<https://blog.peakperf.co/skip-level-manager/>), skip-level bosses control the budget, organizational structure, and the big promotion decisions. For advancement to higher leadership levels, your skip-level boss must know you and what you are capable of.

The research goes further: "Your boss and their peers are the actual decision-makers for promotions. A five-minute phone call from an esteemed colleague of your skip-level on your behalf will accomplish more than any volume of reports, presentations, or interviews."

This is not cynical. It is structural. Leadership promotion decisions require alignment across multiple stakeholders. Your direct manager has one vote. Their peers, their boss, and the broader leadership team fill in the rest.

When you talk only to your manager, you are handing off the entire communication responsibility to a single person. And that person has their own priorities, their own relationship with their boss, and their own read on what the organization needs.

Why Your Manager May Not Be Advocating for You

Here is the part most leadership content leaves out: your manager's incentives may not align with your advancement.

Your manager needs a functioning team. They need their projects staffed. They need someone reliable in the role you are currently in. Moving their best individual contributor into a management role creates a gap they have to fill, on a timeline that usually does not work in your favor.

None of this means your manager is acting in bad faith. Most managers who stall promotions are doing it from a place of team management, not malice. [Research from Fast Company](<https://www.fastcompany.com/91470056/what-to-do-when-your-boss-is-blocking-your-promotion>) identifies this as one of the most common reasons promotions get delayed: managers who cannot imagine losing their top performer become the single gatekeepers who decide who advances and who stalls.

The problem is not intent. The problem is that you have handed your entire career advancement to one person who has a structural reason to keep you where you are. That is a fragile position.

If your manager does not talk to their boss about your goals, or frames the conversation in terms of "we need to find a backfill first," the skip-level leader goes into the promotion discussion without context. They do not have a reason to advocate for you. They may not even know you want the role.

This is exactly what happened to me. I had talked about my goal in every one-on-one for months. My manager knew. His boss had no idea. When I finally sat down with the skip-level boss, he was learning about my goals for the first time. My manager had been quietly pushing me toward a principal IC promotion instead, because that kept me on his team.

I was not angry. He was doing his job. But I had been relying on one person to carry my goals into rooms I never entered. That person had good reasons not to.

Building Career Visibility at the Skip-Level

This is not about going around your manager or creating awkward political dynamics. It is about understanding that promotion decisions are multi-stakeholder events and choosing to show up accordingly.

****Have a direct conversation with your skip-level.**** You do not need a performance crisis or a formal agenda to request 30 minutes with your manager's boss. Most skip-level leaders are glad to connect with high performers two levels down. Keep it simple: you want to share where you are heading and hear their perspective on the team's direction. Say something direct: "I have been building toward a leadership role and I wanted to make sure you had a sense of where I am headed." That one sentence gives them context they can carry into future conversations.

****Build visibility through cross-functional work.**** Every project that touches another department is a chance to be known by leaders who are not your manager. The skip-level boss's peers, the leaders of adjacent teams, and senior stakeholders who see you operate in collaborative settings become informal references. You do not have to perform. You have to show up and do good work in rooms where your manager is not the only person watching.

****State your goals plainly when a senior leader asks.**** When a skip-level leader or senior stakeholder asks what you are working on or where you see yourself going, answer directly. "I am interested in moving into a management role over the next year or two" is not a demand. It is information. Leaders who think you are ready will do something with it.

****Consider a [skip-level meeting](<https://www.fastcompany.com/90777051/what-is-a-skip-level-meeting-and-why-its-key-to-building-your-career>) a career tool, not just an organizational ritual.**** Many companies have skip-level conversations as a standard practice. If yours does, use them intentionally. Come with more than a status update. Share where you want to grow. Ask about what the organization needs from future leaders. These conversations create impressions that outlast the meeting.

One Conversation Most Leaders Never Have

There is a specific conversation that almost no one thinks to have: sitting down with a senior leader and saying plainly, "I want to move into a leadership role. I wanted you to know that, and I wanted to hear your perspective on what that path looks like here."

That conversation feels awkward because it is direct. But directness is exactly what makes it work. You are giving a decision-maker specific information they can act on. You are making it easy for them to carry your name into the right discussions. You are removing the ambiguity about whether you are ready or whether you want it.

Your manager already knows. Now make sure the right people know too.

The action this week

Write down the names of the people above your manager who have any say in your career advancement. Their boss. Their peers. The skip-level leader. Now ask yourself: how many of them know that you want to lead?

If the number is less than two, that is the gap. One conversation this week is enough to start. Ask your manager's boss for 30 minutes, come with something direct to share, and let the conversation begin. The people making decisions about your future cannot advocate for you if they do not know what you want.

Who in your organization, above your direct manager, knows exactly what you want from your career?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building visibility in your organization and advancing your career intentionally, consider reaching out. jessestaffordcoaching.com

Impact Labels: Technical visibility, Career development